

From Gabba rain to MCG shine: The Tour rolls on!

India and Australia face off at the Gabba, where rain disrupts play, India earns a draw, and Ashwin announces retirement. Sportswriters **juggle emotions and deadlines** before heading to Melbourne for the iconic Boxing Day Test.

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There is a lazy charm to Brisbane. It is not too distant and a bit aloof like Perth. Not entirely pastoral like Adelaide. It does not have the rush and frenzy of Melbourne and Sydney. It is a city equally comfortable in its night pyjamas and the full suit.

In this city, India and Australia face off in the third Test at the Gabba. It is the venue where Rishabh Pant orchestrated a superb chase in 2021 to seal the then

Border-Gavaskar Trophy. History cues echo positivity for the Indian unit, still nursing the scars of the previous defeat in the day-and-night Test in Adelaide. But the weather wavers between the grim and the sunny.

Hot chocolate and coffee fly off the shelves inside the press box. Later at night, the nearby German Club is sought by the tired scribes. Frothy brews in tall glasses are quaffed, the odd meatloaf is relished, and the ears strain for the odd snatches of German, but largely it is all about Aussie English and 'Howdya mate?'

